teaching schoolchildren and the general public about India's wildlife.

In the field

Upon his return to India, Ali realized that there were large areas of the subcontinent whose wildlife had not been documented or studied at all. He convinced the BNHS and rulers of several princely states in these areas to fund ornithological surveys. For the next twenty years, Ali travelled all over the subcontinent, from Hyderabad and Kerala to the North-East, observing, recording and collecting hundreds of species of Indian birds. These studies became the basis for several books that documented India's diverse avifauna, their behaviour and habits.



In 1941, Ali published The Book of Indian Birds, which was the first work of its kind in India and is credited with helping to popularize bird-watching and spreading awareness about the importance of conservation.

Looking to the future

Over the years, Ali grew into a well-respected pioneer of Indian ornithology. This enabled him to lend the weight of his experience and knowledge to conservation efforts. At different points, he helped convince Jawaharlal Nehru and Indira Gandhi, respectively, to protect the Bharatpur Bird Sanctuary (now Keoladeo National Park) in Rajasthan as well as the Silent Valley National Park in Kerala. For his work, he received several Indian and